

And that stress is beginning to tell on the human body. Cardiac arrests among young people have become common. Research by the World Health Organization (WHO) and the International Labour Organization (ILO), published in the journal *Environment International* in 2021, revealed that 745,194 people in the 194 countries surveyed died of ischemic heart disease and stroke due to working long hours in 2016, a 29 per cent increase since 2000. The study noted how individuals who worked over 55 hours per week had a 35 per cent higher risk of getting a stroke and a 17 per cent higher risk of dying from ischemic disease compared to those who worked 35-40 hours per week.

**"Deadlines today are dictated by external factors—primarily overseas clients—and could prove unreasonable, leaving companies with little power to negotiate work schedules"**

**- ADITYA MISHRA**
*CEO & MD, CIEL HR*



And it is not just the body that stress manifests in. It does so equally in the mind, triggering mental health issues such as extreme anxiety, feelings of hopelessness, chronic fatigue, depression and even suicidal thoughts. "Think of it like a rubber band," says Karuna Baskar, a counselling psychologist and founder-director of the counselling organisation ResilienceWorks. "If you stretch it for too long, it will snap."

As seems to have been the case for 42-year-old Tarun Saxena, an employee of Bajaj Finance in Jhansi, Uttar Pradesh, who committed suicide on September 30. "I have not slept for 45 days. I have hardly eaten. I am under a lot of stress. Senior managers are pressuring me to meet targets at any cost or quit," his suicide note read. In another incident the same day, 40-year-old bank manager Sushant Chakraborty allegedly jumped from the Atal Setu in Mumbai. His wife blamed work pressure at the public sector bank he worked in for his death.

## WHY THE INDIAN WORKPLACE IS STRESSFUL

People have always worked hard—that fact in isolation is not the problem per se. A person performs best when they feel challenged; no stress at all can lead to unmotivated and bored employees. "It becomes an issue when it goes beyond one's coping abilities," says Baskar. That started becoming the norm in the Indian workplace when we imported the 'rise-and-grind' or 'hustle' culture lock, stock and barrel from Silicon Valley—first into our IT companies, then elsewhere. Only recently Infosys co-founder and former CEO N.R. Narayana Murthy bemoaned that India's youth "have the habit of taking not-so-desirable habits from the West. My request is that our youngsters must say—'This is my country. I want to work 70 hours a week'. This is what the Germans and the Japanese did after the Second World War." But look what it left Japan with. *Karoshi*. Despite the rising tide of misgivings, long hours are still a measure of productivity in the country and an ideal to achieve. "Those who say you shouldn't work weekends have probably never tasted what amazing work is," Hardik Pandya, senior vice-president of design at EdTech company Unacademy, tweeted in March 2023.

Latest data from the ILO actually belies the stereotype of sloth, placing India second among countries that have the highest percentage of people working